FROM BHARAT THAT IS INDIA TO BHARAT VS INDIA?

By KAI FRIESE

What's in a name? When it comes to our argumentative republic, you know the answer will be a deafening cacophony. The ongoing controversy over the putative plot to dispense with 'India' as one of the two official names of our country has led to and been amplified by significant social (and mainstream) media chatter and prompted widespread speculation, mirthful memes, rancour and, of course, colourful conspiracy theories. The immediate backstory, most people would agree, extends to the acronym for the opposition alliance, announced in July. That sleight of brand did seem to rattle the ruling party, provoking a number of ripostes from Prime Minister Narendra Modi who reminded his backbenchers that even the East India Company and the Indian Mujahideen claimed 'India', before going on to pepper the new alliance with 'dots' in Parliament itself. More recently, there was the statement by the RSS chief, urging 'people' to "stop using the word 'India' and start using 'Bharat'." Given that this statement was broadcast a couple of days after the government's announcement of a special session of Parliament to be convened for five days in September, a rumour soon spread connecting these two newsbites.

Such wild surmise became the stuff of TV debate the next day as the news cycle spun off a tweet by BJP chief J.P. Nadda, with a picture of an invitation from the 'President of Bharat' for a formal dinner at Rashtrapati Bhavan on September 9. The stream of memes (including jokes about the fate of this magazine's masthead) thickened, a fresh official document describing Narendra Modi as 'Prime Minister of Bharat' was released, and various government and opposition leaders made the statements you'd expect.

Now, several days into the controversy, there's no evidence that the government has immediate plans to officially drop the name 'India' from the Constitution and all that follows (or what this would involve). But there is some reason to believe that they may enforce the practice of using only 'Bharat' to refer to the country in official documents and parlance, whether in Hindi, English or other languages.

Could this just be an aggressive surrender to counter the Opposition's 'appropriation' of India? Is it merely the latest example of the politics of distraction and narrative disruption in the run-up to the national election next year? The politics of 'Bharat vs India' has been a longer-running theme in the BJP camp. However, it seemed to have become the particular province of the new anglophone intellectuals associated with the government. Ironically, it is this cohort who have lately burnished the locutions 'Indic' and 'Indic civilisation' to promote a piously majoritarian cult of national antiquity. No less ironically, some liberal historians have assailed the tragic erasure of 'Hindustan' by a colonially-conceived Hindu 'India'.

COULD THIS BE JUST AN **AGGRESSIVE SURRENDER** TO COUNTER THE **OPPOSITION'S APPROPRIATION** OF INDIA?

To answer such conundrums, we have resorted to the anciently indigenous but globally popular parable of the 'wise men of Hindustan' (a.k.a. the Blind Men of Indostan), and gathered an assembly of eminent academic, legal, cultural, administrative and political opinion to address the elephant in the room. Read on and you will be rewarded with the diversity of opinion you should expect of this country, whatever you call it. ■